

with others in a way that the company as such gets represented well. These skills are applicable to all internal as well as external forums where employees are making key interactions."

Tina Vas, vice president-global HR, Collabera, says "Simply put, soft skills have more to do with who we are than what we know."

Soft skills critically impact the way an individual translates his expertise across to his team and further to the whole organisation.

Ramana Vemuri, VP-process and operations, Cigniti Technologies, believes that soft skills enhance an individual's interactions, job performance and career prospects. According to him, emotional intelligence is the critical element that defines the core of soft skills a person is equipped with.

Soft skills in today's India

According to a recent report by employability assessment company Aspiring Minds, 56 per cent engineering graduates in India lack soft skills and cognitive skills. Non-technical aspects of engineering such as communications, relationships, temperament, emotional intelligence and risk management make a difference between success and failure. Understanding and adapting to the working environment is just as crucial as getting the job itself.

Prohodsky says, "Engineering is the application of hard sciences to solve real problems but what they rarely teach in colleges is that engineering, in addition to being a technical activity, is an economic activity and, most importantly, a human activity."

According to him, the ability to understand company and work team culture is the most under-appreciated soft skill.

Bhagat says, "As companies become more global, soft skills are highly desirable and required in more positions now than ten or even five years ago. You may have an excellent knowledge base in engineering or technology, perhaps even a PhD, and maybe bilingual but if you have not developed good skills in communicating, interacting and people resource management, you have already limited

your opportunities and chance of success."

Vas adds, "Networking is also important; engineers need to keep in touch with alumni as well as industry experts via various interactive forums to understand the ground realities better."

Why you should continuously improve your soft skills

"Soft skills are applied emotional intelligence and as such, they are very important. As engineers, we are taught to think and apply the logic of math and science. However, we are being ruled by emotions," says Prohodsky.

Soft skills are very essential for personal and professional development of individuals. "In today's economy, it is even more important considering a significant portion of Indian GDP comes from services sector. To support this growth in services sector, organisations require talents who possess greater soft skills along with hard skills," notes Rajesh Choudhary.

"Technical skills may take you to the doorstep but it is your soft skills that will open up the door for you," believes Dr Pallab.

Adding on the growing importance of soft skills in today's world, Vemuri says, "They (soft skills) are in demand than ever. Increasing possibility of interactions with global peers, customers, virtual teams and cross-cultural discussions mandate employers to look out for fine-tuned, polished workforce."

"Soft skills facilitate efficiency and effectiveness at work," says Sunil Pathak, HR director, Cadence Design Systems. While flawless technical expertise is the primary necessity, soft skills are imperative to ensure high-quality contribution and delivery.

Pandit explains, "An engineer might be excellent at writing code to solve a particular problem but unless he possesses soft skills, he would neither be able to understand the problem faced by a customer nor explain how his suggested method makes the best fitted solution for the customer's problem."

Dr Pallab believes that soft skills are as important as technical skills

Myth Buster

Myth 1: It is the hard skills (technical skills) that get you a job, not soft skills.

Truth: You need to balance both.

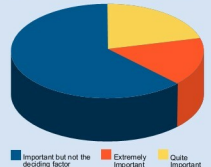
Myth 2: Being strong in analytical aptitude, quantitative expertise and information-gathering ability is enough to fetch a job.

Truth: In addition to the above, you need strategic thinking, written and oral communication skills, leadership skills, and adaptability.

A 'soft skills' survey

Recently, EFY conducted an opinion survey of engineering students, fresh professionals and industry analysts through various social media platforms to understand the importance of soft skills, apart from tech knowhow, for a successful career.

62.63 per cent respondents believed that soft skills were important but not the deciding factor. 25.29 per cent believed that soft skills were extremely important. Remaining 12.08 per cent believed that these were important as complementary skills.



EFY Survey results on soft skills across various social media platforms

due to two main factors: "One is that employees are being sent on projects to international locations, where they need to articulate their thoughts and actions to become productive. Second, with enhanced globalisation, virtual communication has taken a front seat in today's organisations."

An engineer is rewarded for his ability to make decisions, manage risks and creativity. Therefore soft skills are vital for an individual to get employed and grow in an organisation.

Hard skills vs soft skills—what you should focus on

Let's take the example of software engineers. They need to be skilled in soft-